

Cured or flatlined?

A recent Symantec report – based on data gained from enterprise solutions of theirs – says spam is finally dying out. For the first time in over a decade, spam accounted for under 50 per cent of emails. With them calling it a five-year-low in spam, this news suggests that finally the effort versus reward ratio of spammers is falling drastically enough to finally see a significant reduction. And the security companies say it's their anti-spam filtering that's caused this.

Back in 2013, Kaspersky also released results of a similar study which was a new five-year-low back then. Somewhere around 72 per cent of email back then was spam. From 72 per cent to just under 50 per cent is a rather large dip. One that no one will ever complain about, but a significant, and thus interesting dip nonetheless.

What's even more interesting is that the total amount of email being sent per day is still going up! Of course enterprise users account for most of the email being sent out, which estimates suggest is between 180 to 220 billion email messages a day. Yes. 220 billion. Per day. On average. Of this, about 100 to 120 billion are enterprise mail, and 80 to 100 are end-user emails. That's all of us 2 billion-ish people who are online, emailing using private services such as Gmail.

It comes as no surprise to me that many experts believe that the total amount of email sent is soon going to start reducing, or at least become more stagnant a number, to start with. The newest generation that's joining the online technology population just don't like email as much as their older counterparts.

Now, I'm old, especially in technology years! I may be in my late 30s, but even I can testify to an ever reducing reliability on email to communicate personally. Not for work though! That's one area where I am still totally dependent on email, and perhaps the main reason why I'm still using a BlackBerry 10 phone instead of Android one – they're just awesome for email!

I get between 200 to 1000 emails a day in my official inbox. Of this, about 100 make it through to my priority inbox, and about 30 need me to respond to them immediately as they arrive. The other 70 are either forwarded to others or only require me to read and forget about them. The ones that don't make it to my priority inbox I either make time for at the end of every day, or on a weekend; though I've also been guilty of getting to it only after a month! Some of you

readers who have got a reply from me many moons later will testify to this.

Anyway, that's a typical workday for me in terms of emailing people. Like every other person on the planet, I also have a personal email account, and although that's also configured on my BlackBerry, it's not something I get to every day. Sometimes it's only once a week that I get to emails from the few friends and family members who still communicate only that way with me – usually people over 50, or those who live in really small towns and don't own smartphones.

That's just how it's become. Instant personal communication is done through WhatsApp, or some other IM, and official work is done over email. Not for long though, because at Digit we already do most of our communicating with colleagues over WhatsApp. Enterprise users are already using other services such as Asana for team collaboration, and Slack for better communication, rather than just depending on email.

Coming back to the non-work experience though, I've got more WhatsApp spam in the last year than ever before. It's a lot easier to block them, but they did try. I don't even encounter ads on the web. It's only as paid facebook posts or in-app advertising these days.

The simple fact is, as slowly as the ice caps are melting, email for personal use is dying. It's finished. Kaput. Gone. Obsolete. Yes, I'm exaggerating. I'm jumping the gun. With good reason, though. If the porn industry, the spammer industry and the malicious code industry start jumping ship, you know you're on the technology equivalent of the Titanic!

As much as security companies would like to thump their chests and stake claim on the laurels for finally defeating the spammers, the fact is the game has changed, and it's us that changed it – by developing new habits. What we should ask ourselves is whether it's the cancer that's being defeated gradually, or the patient that's slowly dying? Has email been saved, or is it just dying a natural death? Cured or flatlined? What do you think? 



Robert Sovereign-Smith
Executive Editor
robert@digit.in

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